

was held up by pillars considered to be unshakeable: capitalism, communism, socialism, free markets, abundant natural resources, world economic growth and peaceful co-existence. Today, all the long established supremacy of these ideas is being challenged by a series of curtailed crises over our safety and security, our financial future and degradation of our environment. All the 'isms' have collapsed or are damaged. All over the world, countries are struggling to devise strategies of getting out of the mess that the world finds itself in the 21st Century. What is the best form of governance? What mixture of 'isms' will emerge? What new international institutions need to be set up to deal with our super-connected world? Do we need a new ethical construct of how we live and work? These and many more, Ladies and Gentlemen, are the challenges of change.

Between the first Conclave and the present one, it has been a long, uneven narrative of change. Some for the better. Some for the worse. At home, the so-called stoic state with a soft core suffered in silence, as datelines of terror multiplied. Mumbai. Delhi. Jaipur, Ahmedabad. India was fast emerging as the biggest victim of radical Islam. And that too an incomprehensively passive one. It was as if lives were cheaper here, and jihad an easy vocation. Politically too, it has been a period of shifts and turns, of changes in faces and fortunes. When we assembled here for the first Conclave, India's first right wing government was in power. It was a historic shift in a country whose politics was essentially Left-Centre. The Indian Right proved unworthy of the mandate; in five years they would be defeated by their own slogan of a shining India. Few romances in politics have ended so abruptly.

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Ladies and Gentlemen, we seem to have come a full circle. Last year, as I stood here and talked about the leadership for the new century, the Democratic primaries were underway. The freshman senator from Illinois was already the wunderkind, taking on the huge Clinton machinery with words resonant with the message of Change. Candidate Obama turned a cliché as old as politics into a weapon of mass seduction. Quoting Mahatma Gandhi, he said: "Be the Change You Want in the World." President Obama's challenge is about managing change.

Mumbai 2008—what we have come to call 26/11—has revealed the vulnerability of the victim, and the reach and rage of the enemy. Terror in the name of God is the biggest threat to our survival. I believe the audacity of the Mumbai attacks and our response awakened the middle class to the fact that the fountainhead of a country is its politics. And if that is rotten then the various arms of the state like the bureaucracy, the police and security forces would be compromised by corruption, cronyism, non-accountability, lethargy and adhocism as was revealed during the Mumbai attacks and subsequent investigations. Hopefully, in the next general elections, it will not only make more people vote, but vote differently.

Ladies and Gentlemen, in a world changed by the nihilism of religion and the vicissitudes of capitalism, by the changes in climate and the advances in science, the challenges are manifold. To face up to them, we need a global leadership that is not subordinated to the straitjacket of ideology. We need a leadership that is fascinated with ideas. Change is born out of the passions and impatience of man. In its extreme, it was called revolution, which led to liberation or tyranny, progress or mass graves. In modern times too, it was a few extraordinary leaders who turned historic changes into opportunities of freedom and national renewal.

Today's challenges are manifold. Today, the sweep of change in politics, economy, science and in religious radicalism, is a challenge as well as an opportunity. All said, I'm modest enough to admit that a Conclave cannot change the world. It can certainly change the way we look at it. If the world looks a bit different by tomorrow evening, it will be change worth toasting.

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